NCCA ENTERTAINMENT

THE LINE

"When you don't own what you built, how far will you go to take it back?"

STUDIO EDITION

SERIES BIBLE • PRINCIPAL CASTING • COMPLETE SEASON GUIDE

ONE-HOUR CRIME THRILLER • 8 EPISODES • ATLANTA

STUDIO EDITION

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SECTION 01

NCCA ENTERTAINMENT

THE SERIES

The buyer-facing creative proposition: concept, engine, characters, world, tone and the Season One promise.

THE LINE

SEASON ONE, COMPLETE • SERIES BIBLE

> After an assassination attempt exposes the criminal machinery beneath her Atlanta music empire, ambitious music executive Monique “Mo” Sanders is forced into an uneasy alliance with Tom Whitaker, an FBI agent posing as her head of security. Together they uncover a conspiracy connecting Atlanta's music business, organized crime, law enforcement, and Mo's own family, and prove that the catalog she inherited from her dying father was stolen out from under her through a fraudulent deal.

THE WORLD

THE LINE is a propulsive Atlanta crime thriller set at the intersection of hip-hop, money, family, and institutional power. Monique Sanders spent eight years transforming her late father's struggling label, MSMG, into a rising force in Atlanta music, certain she had finally escaped the streets that consumed her family. Then somebody tried to kill her.

The FBI quietly embedded disgraced but formidable agent Tom Whitaker inside MSMG as Monique's new head of security. His target was Dexter Miles, a polished criminal power broker whose organization had woven itself into Atlanta's music economy through predatory contracts, shell companies, and publishing rights. What neither Tom nor Monique understood at the start of the season was that Dexter was never the ceiling. He was, in his own words by the finale, just the floor you could see.

Season One resolves cleanly across eight episodes: who stole Philip Sanders's legacy, what it cost Mo and Tom to take it back, and who was really standing above the man they both thought they were hunting.

THE SEASON ONE ENGINE

TOM: OUTWARD

Across eight episodes, Tom's outward investigation moves from a name nobody would say out loud, Harlan Vess, to a face, a warrant, and an arrest executed in the same hour as Dexter's own. It costs him his badge along the way, suspended mid-season by an Office of Professional Responsibility hearing that very nearly ends his career before the case does.

MO: INWARD

Across eight episodes, Mo's inward investigation moves from a missing signature, Schedule B, to the real document, handed to her personally by the uncle who kept it from her, inside the ruined building where her father's label began. It costs her the comfortable belief that the people closest to her, Lyle, Becca, even her own brother, were protecting her by keeping her in the dark.

TONE + WORLD

> *BODYGUARD × SNOWFALL × THE WIRE, with the music-industry power dynamics of EMPIRE, grounded as a contemporary serialized crime thriller.*

Atlanta is not scenery. It is infrastructure: studios, nightclubs, federal offices, legacy Black businesses, Buckhead money, Midtown law firms, street economies, new Atlanta colliding with old Atlanta, all the way back to Sweet Auburn and Auburn Avenue. Music drives the world without turning the series into a musical. Every track carries artistic, cultural, and ownership value at once, and the soundtrack becomes both storytelling device and commercial extension of the series.

THEMES

Ownership. Trust. Legacy. Survival. Redemption. Season One's real answer: ownership is not a signature on a document. It is a choice, renewed under pressure, about what you do with power once you finally hold it. The finale's closing image, Mo choosing to mail four hundred twelve families' secrets back unsigned rather than keep the leverage for herself, is the show's thesis made visible.

THE SEASON ONE STORY

It begins with a livestream that goes wrong. Kane Frost films his own commentary straight into a gas-station ambush, and survives only because the shooter never finishes the job. Mo learns, within the hour, that the target was never Kane. It was her. The FBI quietly places disgraced agent Tom Whitaker inside MSMG as her new head of security, and a second, bolder ambush at the Velvet Club proves the first night was no isolated incident. By the pilot's final scene, Mo's own assistant has already unmasked Tom's cover, and she says his real name to his face.

Episode 2 makes the war official on two fronts at once. Dexter answers the club shooting with lawyers instead of shooters, a five-million-dollar suit tied to Luna Lux's signing, while Mo confronts Lyle directly about a missing document called Schedule B for the first time in the series. He stonewalls her, visibly shaken, the first real crack in the man who held everything together since Philip died. Luna finally opens the envelope she has carried since the pilot: not a contract, a damaging internal MSMG financial document, confirming someone inside the building is already feeding Dexter's camp.

Episode 3 sends Mo after Schedule B herself. The trail leads to the Midtown firm that handled the 2017 refinancing, where the file was checked out eight years earlier and never returned, by Lyle. Confronted with the paper trail, he finally admits Philip signed something in the hospital, medicated, days before he died, though whether that is the whole truth is left open. For the first time, Mo's incarcerated brother Sandy asks to see her.

Episode 4 is the season's structural hinge. In the prison visiting room, Sandy finally tells Mo everything: years ago he took a plea to protect the family, and he has been quietly cooperating with the FBI ever since. Mo is not the first Sanders the Bureau has used. She just did not know she had company. Tom, independently, discovers his own cover identity was built years before his assignment, by someone who wanted Mo to trust him before he ever walked through her door.

> *Mo is not the first Sanders the Bureau has used. She just didn't know she had company.*

Episodes 5 and 6 give the mystery its first real name. Mo builds a shadow company, Southern Crown Holdings, to move her artists out of Dexter's reach, while an old Sweet Auburn fixture confirms a nameless man has quietly owned pieces of Atlanta for fifty years. Kane's viral rooftop confession turns MSMG's war into a national headline, and that same night someone firebombs his car with his eight-year-old cousin thirty feet away. Tom trades his badge for a notarized page tying the name Harlan Vess to a 1987 filing, and Lyle finally confesses the 1981 debt behind that name has always been his to carry, not Philip's.

Episode 7 delivers the season's emotional reckoning. With Tom's career on the line at an OPR hearing and Sandy jumped in the prison yard, Lyle takes Mo back to the boarded-up ruins of Sanders Sound and hands her the real, physical Schedule B. The name behind the ring belongs to two people: Harlan Vess, and a missing witness named Ruth Ann Colby who has been running from both of them for thirty-nine years.

Episode 8 closes the season clean. Harlan Vess finally speaks to Mo directly, from inside his own archive, and she decides, in real time, what kind of owner she is going to become now that she has won. Federal warrants take Dexter and Vess into custody within the same hour, Ruth Ann Colby gives her full statement, and Mo, Rachel, Becca, and Chandra spend one night choosing to mail four hundred twelve families' secrets back unsigned rather than keep the leverage. Lyle steps down. And days later, a new voice reaches the FBI bullpen: Vess is in custody. The file is not closed. It has changed hands.

THE MYTHOLOGY: SIX THREADS, SIX PAYOFFS

SCHEDULE B

The missing 2017 refinancing document. Introduced in Episode 2, chased through Episode 3's checked-out file and Episode 4's partial confession, resolved in Episode 7 when Lyle personally hands Mo the real, physical document at the ruined Sanders Sound building and finally admits the debt behind it was always his.

THE NAME BEHIND THE TRUST

First heard as a shadow figure in the Episode 2 parking-garage bug, resolved across Episodes 5 through 7 as the season's true antagonist, Harlan Vess, and fully dramatized in the Episode 8 finale.

TOM'S BUG

Planted in the pilot, pays off on schedule in Episode 2, catching a voice in the MSMG parking garage that begins the season-long hunt for who Lyle has really been protecting.

SANDY'S FBI CONNECTION

Teased in Episode 3, fully revealed to Mo in Episode 4's midpoint confession: she is not the first Sanders the Bureau has used. She simply did not know she had company.

LUNA'S ENVELOPE

Carried since the pilot, opened in Episode 2. Not a contract, a damaging internal MSMG financial document, confirming someone inside the building is already feeding Dexter's camp.

WHO ORDERED THE HITS

The gas-station and Velvet Club ambushes are confirmed, across the season, to have nothing to do with Dexter at all. Two loose associates acted without his sanction. The real threat behind the season traces back to the same Harlan Vess operation Tom spends eight episodes closing in on.

WHY IT SELLS

THE LINE combines an accessible thriller engine with a world television rarely explores from this angle: the economics behind Atlanta's music culture. Season One delivers on all of it across eight episodes: assassination attempts, an undercover FBI operation, and organized crime, resolved through a genuine music-industry engine where publishing contracts, royalty streams, and catalogs become instruments of power. That gives the series multiple commercial lanes at once: a serialized crime mystery, an action thriller, a family drama, a music-industry drama, premium soundtrack opportunities, emerging-artist integration, and a strong central two-hander in Tom and Mo.

> *Season One pays off its own binge question in full: who stole Philip Sanders's legacy, and what did Mo have to become to take it back?*

SEASON TWO: THE IGNITION

The finale closes its own season cleanly: Dexter and Harlan Vess both in custody, four hundred twelve families getting their secrets back, Lyle stepping down, Tom and Mo both choosing, separately, what kind of people they are going to be now that the case is over. Then the phone rings one more time. A new voice reaches the FBI bullpen days later: Vess is in custody. The file is not closed. It has changed hands. Season Two opens on the question Season One never got to ask. If Harlan Vess was never the ceiling, who is?

THE LINE

ONE-HOUR CRIME THRILLER • 8 EPISODES • ATLANTA

"When you don't own what you built, how far will you go to take it back?"

LOGLINE

After an assassination attempt exposes the criminal machinery beneath her Atlanta music empire, ambitious music executive **Monique "Mo" Sanders** is forced into an uneasy alliance with **Tom Whitaker**, an FBI agent posing as her head of security. Together they uncover a conspiracy connecting Atlanta's music business, organized crime, law enforcement, and Mo's own family, including evidence that the catalog she inherited from her dying father may have been stolen through a fraudulent deal.

THE SERIES

THE LINE is a propulsive Atlanta crime thriller set at the intersection of hip-hop, money, family and institutional power.

Monique Sanders has spent eight years transforming her late father's struggling label, MSMG, into a rising force in Atlanta music. She believes she's finally escaped the streets that consumed her family.

Then somebody tries to kill her.

The FBI quietly embeds disgraced but formidable agent Tom Whitaker inside MSMG as Mo's new security chief. His target is Dexter Miles, a polished criminal power broker whose organization has quietly embedded itself in Atlanta's music economy through predatory contracts, shell companies and publishing rights.

But Mo soon discovers something more devastating than Dexter's criminal operation:

> *Dexter already owns sixty percent of the music empire she thought belonged to her.*

The trail leads back to 2017, when her father Philip was dying and her uncle Lyle Sanders made a desperate deal to keep the company alive. A missing contract schedule, suspicious signatures and medical records raise an even darker possibility:

> *Philip Sanders may never have signed his catalog away at all.*

Now Mo and Tom are fighting the same enemy for very different reasons. Tom needs Mo to penetrate Dexter's organization. Mo needs Tom to help uncover who stole her father's legacy.

And neither knows whether the greatest threat is outside MSMG… or already inside the family.

THE ENGINE

Every episode pushes two investigations toward collision.

TOM: OUTWARD

Follows the criminal conspiracy outward: Dexter's money, shooters, shell corporations, corrupt officials, and the larger organization operating above him.

MO: INWARD

Follows the family conspiracy inward: her father's catalog, the missing Schedule B, her imprisoned brother Sandy's secret FBI connection, and what Lyle really did in 2017.

Meanwhile, Mo begins quietly building a clean catalog: a financial lifeboat designed to protect her artists from Dexter's ownership structure.

The deeper Tom and Mo go, the more dangerous the central question becomes:

> *Where is the line between protecting someone and using them?*

MONIQUE "MO" SANDERS | 32

Music Executive. Survivor. Heir to an empire she may not actually own.

Brilliant, ambitious and Atlanta-born, Mo can read a contract, a room and a threat before most people realize one exists. She built MSMG into something her father would have recognized as a legacy. Discovering that Dexter has quietly profited from everything she's created turns survival into war.

Mo isn't Tom's protected asset. She's his partner, whether the FBI likes it or not.

TOM WHITAKER | 42

FBI Agent. Protector. A man carrying one dead asset too many.

Former military intelligence turned FBI field operative, Tom comes to Atlanta carrying the stain of a disastrous Dallas operation that left a civilian asset dead. His assignment is simple: infiltrate MSMG as Mo's security chief, keep her alive, and use her access to reach Dexter.

Then Tom starts caring whether Mo survives for reasons that aren't in his case file.

LYLE SANDERS | 60S

Uncle. Protector. Keeper of the original sin.

Lyle helped raise Mo and kept her father's company alive when it was collapsing. Mo sees him as family, mentor, and the man who preserved her inheritance.

Dexter tells a different story. And Lyle's secret ledger, his mysterious contact known only as "R," and his knowledge of the missing contract documents suggest he has spent eight years protecting far more than Mo.

DEXTER MILES | 40S

Criminal entrepreneur. Music power broker. The man who already owns the board.

Dexter doesn't need to kick down doors: he owns the paper behind them. Sophisticated, patient and frighteningly informed, Dexter has turned contracts, publishing rights and financial leverage into weapons as effective as guns.

His greatest advantage is simple: everyone thinks they're playing against him before realizing they're already playing for him.

TONE + WORLD

> *BODYGUARD × SNOWFALL × THE WIRE, with the music-industry power dynamics of EMPIRE, grounded as a contemporary serialized crime thriller.*

Atlanta isn't scenery. It's infrastructure. Studios. Nightclubs. Federal offices. Legacy Black businesses. Buckhead money. Midtown law firms. Street economies. New Atlanta colliding with old Atlanta.

Music drives the world without turning the series into a musical. Every track has artistic value, cultural value and, critically, ownership value.

The soundtrack becomes part of the storytelling, and a commercial extension of the series.

THEMES

OWNERSHIP | TRUST | LEGACY | SURVIVAL | REDEMPTION

- Who owns the art?
- Who owns the business?
- Who owns the truth?
- What happens when the people who claim to be protecting you have secretly been making decisions for you?

At its heart, THE LINE is about two people who have stopped trusting institutions learning, very cautiously, to trust each other.

WHY IT SELLS

THE LINE combines an accessible thriller engine with a world television rarely explores from this angle: the economics behind Atlanta's music culture.

The pilot delivers assassination attempts, undercover FBI operations and organized crime, but its distinctive weapon is ownership. Publishing contracts, royalty streams and catalogs become instruments of power.

That gives the series multiple commercial lanes: a serialized crime mystery, action thriller, family drama, music-industry drama, premium soundtrack opportunities, emerging-artist integration, and a strong central two-hander.

> *Season One contains a clean binge question: who stole Philip Sanders' legacy, and what will Mo have to become to take it back?*

SECTION 02

NCCA ENTERTAINMENT

PRINCIPAL CASTING

A focused packaging strategy for the four roles that define the creative and market position of the series.

CASTING SUGGESTIONS

The Room

The casting list below reflects the rewritten pilot, not the original pitch. In particular: Mo is now 32, Dexter has become considerably more sophisticated, and Lyle requires an actor who can make us love him while simultaneously making us wonder whether he's capable of something terrible.

Four roles, each with a first choice and ranked alternates, followed by two assembled packages, a prestige version and a commercial/music-forward version, and the pairing the show is actually built to live or die on.

> *Bernthal + Fishback: two people who'd irritate the hell out of each other, save each other's lives, distrust each other's institutions, and eventually realize the other person may be the only one in Atlanta telling them the truth.*

CASTING STRATEGY
Casting references indicate performance tone and market position, not pre-negotiated attachments. The buyer-facing package concentrates named talent on the four principal roles; recurring and guest roles can combine selective prestige casting with Atlanta-based talent according to platform and budget.

TOM WHITAKER

FBI Agent · 42

JB

Jon Bernthal FIRST CHOICE

Still the strongest choice. He naturally gives Tom the thing the character needs most: contained violence. You believe he can walk quietly through MSMG for twenty minutes and then put two rounds through a four-inch opening without changing expression.

JK

Joel Kinnaman ALTERNATE

The strongest premium-thriller alternative, especially for Tom's military/FBI history and emotional reserve.

JD

Josh Duhamel ALTERNATE

Pushes Tom toward classic network-leading-man territory and broadens the procedural accessibility.

RANKING: BERNTHAL → KINNAMAN → DUHAMEL

MONIQUE "MO" SANDERS

Music Executive · 32

DF

Dominique Fishback — FIRST CHOICE

The rewritten Mo needs enormous intelligence behind the eyes. Fishback can make Mo's silences active, and some of her strongest moments involve realizing that someone she trusts has lied to her.

KP

Keke Palmer — COMMERCIAL FIRST CHOICE

Changes the package: star power, music credibility, humor, cultural recognition and marketing firepower. Makes Mo louder and more charismatic than Fishback's interpretation, not necessarily a drawback.

RD

Ryan Destiny — BREAKOUT / YOUNGER GLAMOUR

Gives MSMG immediate music-industry authenticity and leans into Mo's executive glamour.

RANKING: FISHBACK (PRESTIGE) → PALMER (COMMERCIAL PACKAGING) → DESTINY (MUSIC-WORLD HEAT)

LYLE SANDERS

Uncle · 60s · This role has become much more important

WP

Wendell Pierce — FIRST CHOICE

Almost tailor-made for the rewrite. Warmth, authority, history and moral ambiguity. Most importantly, an audience would trust him, which makes the possibility of betrayal hurt.

CV

Courtney B. Vance — PRESTIGE ALTERNATIVE

Would make Lyle's intelligence more visible and the 2017 mystery potentially darker.

CP

Clifton Powell — ATLANTA / GENRE AUTHENTICITY

Gives Lyle a harder street history immediately.

RANKING: PIERCE → VANCE → POWELL

DEXTER MILES

Power Broker · 40s · A potential breakout antagonist

SB

Sterling K. Brown — FIRST CHOICE

Against expected type, and lethal for it. Dexter isn't a stereotypical gangster; he's articulate, financially sophisticated and completely comfortable around power. Brown could make the cigar-alley conversation terrifying without raising his voice.

CD

Colman Domingo — ALTERNATE

If Dexter is aged slightly, Domingo could turn him into an extraordinary Atlanta kingmaker: elegant, charismatic, dangerous.

TR

Trevante Rhodes — HARDER ALTERNATIVE

Younger and more physically imposing, a different Dexter: less patriarch, more contemporary mogul.

RANKING: BROWN → DOMINGO → RHODES

Note: Rhodes moves from the original Dexter Miles casting slot into consideration for Dexter himself; the rewritten role deserves serious casting capital.

THE PACKAGE I'D TAKE INTO A ROOM

PRESTIGE VERSION

Jon Bernthal · Dominique Fishback

Wendell Pierce · Sterling K. Brown

That's a serious ensemble.

COMMERCIAL / MUSIC-FORWARD VERSION

Josh Duhamel · Keke Palmer

Clifton Powell · Trevante Rhodes

Two different versions of the same property.

But the dream pairing remains **Bernthal + Fishback**, because the show lives or dies on Tom and Mo having chemistry that isn't immediately romantic. They should look like two people who would irritate the hell out of each other, save each other's lives, distrust each other's institutions, and eventually realize the other person may be the only one in Atlanta telling them the truth.

THE LINE

"Everybody owns a piece. Nobody owns the truth."

SECTION 03

NCCA ENTERTAINMENT

SEASON ONE

Eight episodes. One escalating ownership conspiracy. Each chapter changes what Mo and Tom believe the system is.

THE LINE

EPISODE 1 (PILOT) • "COLLISION COURSE" • THE FIRST TARGET WAS NEVER THE POINT

> MSMG's biggest artist livestreams himself into a sniper's sightline outside a Midtown gas station and survives only because the shooter never finishes the job. Monique Sanders learns, within the hour, that she was the actual target. By the time the FBI quietly places disgraced agent Tom Whitaker inside MSMG as her new head of security, a second ambush and one background check are already closing the distance between them: he isn't **Mike Daniels**. He never was.

THE STORY

Kane Frost, MSMG's most visible artist, films his own commentary all the way into a gas station and straight into an idling SUV's crosshairs. He survives, shaken, staring at an empty passenger seat that should have had a second shooter in it. Lyle's call that night reframes the whole cold open for Monique: the SUV was never hunting Kane. It was hunting her, and she happened to cancel dinner.

At the FBI's Atlanta field office, Agent Karen Bailey and Tom Whitaker map Dexter Miles's operation across a wall that already includes Monique's incarcerated brother, Sandy. Tom is placed inside MSMG within days, posing as security consultant Mike Daniels, and clocks a broken gate and a dead camera before he's even met his new boss. Lyle doesn't buy him for a second.

At the Velvet Club, Luna Lux's MSMG signing detonates in front of Dexter's own VIP table, and a second, far bolder ambush in the parking lot proves the gas station was not a one-off. Monique pockets a stolen vendor contract page the same night her assistant's background check surfaces a name that was never supposed to reach her: Thomas Whitaker, FBI. By the episode's final scene, she says it to his face.

> *Since the night you put your body between me and a sedan full of bullets and called it Tuesday.*

ESCALATING OBSTACLE

Monique's own assistant unmasks Tom's cover before he has earned an inch of her trust, and the season's first two ambushes make clear the threat is not Dexter settling a score. It is someone neither of them can yet name, moving through people they both thought were safe.

KEY MOMENTS

- **Gas Station Ambush.** Kane Frost livestreams himself into a sniper's sightline outside a Midtown gas station and survives only because the SUV never finishes the job.
- **Not Kane. Her.** Lyle's call reframes the whole cold open: the SUV was never hunting Kane. It was hunting Monique, and she happened to cancel dinner.
- **Mike Daniels Starts Work.** Tom Whitaker walks into MSMG as Monique's new head of security over Lyle's open suspicion, and clocks the building's broken security inside of five minutes.
- **The Velvet Club Erupts.** Luna's MSMG signing detonates in front of Dexter's own VIP table, and a second, bolder ambush in the parking lot proves the first night wasn't an isolated incident.
- **Two Secrets, Same Night.** Monique pockets a stolen vendor contract page and learns, in the same hour, that Mike Daniels does not exist. Both secrets are about to get somebody killed.
- **Thomas Whitaker.** Monique confronts Tom by name. He doesn't deny it. The alliance the whole series runs on starts here, with neither of them lying anymore.

THE ENGINE, THIS EPISODE

TOM: OUTWARD

Dropped into MSMG as Mike Daniels with one broken gate and one dead camera to exploit, and a target in Dexter Miles who doesn't yet know Tom is inside the building.

MO: INWARD

A stolen contract page in her purse and a name she can't unlearn, Thomas Whitaker, FBI, delivered by her own assistant before midnight.

ATLANTA TEXTURE (LOCKED LOCATIONS)

- MSMG headquarters, a repurposed textile warehouse in Midtown Atlanta
- A Midtown gas station, buzzing fluorescents (the cold-open ambush)
- FBI Atlanta Field Office, Spring Street
- Titan Elite Exotic, the showroom and the garage behind it
- The Velvet Club, and the service alley behind it
- Monique's office, MSMG (the reveal)

THE LINE

EPISODE 2 • "SIXTY PERCENT" • THE WAR BECOMES OFFICIAL

The club shooting is national news, and Mo's name is public. Tom's evidence confirms Dexter's shell company is real, but Bailey is furious he let a civilian this far in, and Dexter answers with lawyers instead of shooters: a five-million-dollar tortious interference suit tied to the Luna Lux signing. Mo is now fighting a legal war on top of a criminal one, and the case turns on one document she doesn't have. Schedule B.

THE STORY

For the first time, Mo confronts Lyle directly about Schedule B. He stonewalls, but he's visibly shaken, the first crack in the man who's held everything together since Philip died.

Luna finally opens the envelope from the pilot. It isn't a contract. It's a partial financial document about MSMG itself, damaging and specific, and it means someone inside MSMG's own paperwork is feeding Dexter's camp. The infiltration question opens here, and it doesn't close for the rest of the season.

And in the parking garage, Tom's forgotten bug from the pilot finally starts transmitting on schedule. It catches a voice after midnight, someone meeting Lyle in person, not on the phone. A face in shadow. Not yet identified.

> *Dexter already owns sixty percent of the music empire she thought belonged to her.*

ESCALATING OBSTACLE

Mo now has two enemies capable of destroying her: Dexter's guns and Dexter's lawyers. And the one person she trusted completely to have her back on the legal front is now, visibly, hiding something material to her own defense.

KEY MOMENTS

- **Sources Say.** Kane's livestream and the club shooting become a real headline. Mo's danger stops being a secret the moment it becomes a story.
- **The Shell Confirmed.** Tom's vendor-page discovery reaches the Bureau's financial crimes unit. South Metro Touring is proven to be Dexter's, on paper: real proof, but not enough to move on him yet.
- **Lawyers, Not Shooters.** Franklin & Voss files a five-million-dollar tortious interference claim over the Luna Lux signing. The war goes legal, and Rachel Okonkwo steps in as Mo's counsel.
- **The First Stonewall.** Mo asks Lyle for Schedule B, directly, for the first time in the series. He shuts the door on her, and for the first time, she notices.
- **The Envelope, Opened.** Luna finally opens what she's been carrying since the pilot. It isn't what anyone expected.
- **The Bug Wakes Up.** A voice in the parking garage, after midnight. Someone is meeting Lyle in person. We don't see a face yet.

THE ENGINE, THIS EPISODE

TOM: OUTWARD

The shell company is confirmed. The evidence is real. Bailey's institutional caution collides with how far Tom already let Mo in.

MO: INWARD

The missing document, the stonewalling uncle, the opened envelope. The infiltration question is born here and will not close all season.

ATLANTA TEXTURE (LOCKED LOCATIONS)

- The newsroom coverage of the shooting (real Atlanta outlet, name TBD)
- The club front (real Atlanta club, name TBD)
- The MSMG parking garage (established in the pilot; the bug thread continues)

THE LINE

EPISODE 3 • "SCHEDULE B" • THE DOCUMENT THAT ISN'T THERE

Mo stops waiting on Lyle and goes after Schedule B herself. The trail leads to the Midtown firm that handled the 2017 refinancing, where the file was checked out eight years ago and never returned, by Lyle. Confronted with the paper trail, he finally gives up a partial truth. And for the first time, her incarcerated brother Sandy asks to see her.

THE STORY

The Bureau's financial team traces Dexter's Panama routing to a specific fixer inside the bank who could testify to it. Tom goes outside his official lane to make contact himself, against Bailey's direct order: the first real crack in his discipline, the first moment the Dallas parallel stops being a thing Bailey says to him and starts being a thing he's actually doing.

Confronted with the checked-out file, Lyle finally admits Philip signed something in the hospital, medicated, days before he died, and that Lyle has always doubted his brother understood what he was signing. He insists he didn't know Dexter was the buyer until later. Whether that's the whole truth is left open.

> *Sandy heard about the shooting. He says he needs to warn her about something. He doesn't give up what he knows this episode; he's testing whether she can be trusted with it.*

And Becca comes to Mo first, unprompted: someone anonymous has been offering her money for Mo's schedule and movements. She hasn't taken it, and she's scared. The loyalty test lands in Mo's favor, but it confirms MSMG's inner circle is being actively worked from the outside, not just watched.

ESCALATING OBSTACLE

Schedule B itself may no longer exist. If the document is gone, the clean paper-trail win Mo was hoping for is off the table; she's going to have to rely on testimony instead, which means either Lyle's word or her dead father's final, medicated days. A much more painful excavation than a document hunt.

KEY MOMENTS

- **Off the Lane.** Tom approaches the bank fixer himself, directly disobeying Bailey. The first real crack in his discipline.
- **The Checked-Out File.** Mo and Rachel discover the 2017 refinancing file was pulled eight years ago and never returned, by Lyle.
- **A Partial Truth.** Cornered by the paper trail, Lyle finally admits Philip signed something in the hospital, medicated, days before he died.
- **Sandy, For the First Time.** Mo's incarcerated brother requests a visit for the first time in years, and tests her with a specific childhood memory before he'll trust her with anything real.
- **The Loyalty Test.** Becca tells Mo, unprompted, that someone's been trying to buy her. She hasn't sold. It confirms MSMG is being worked from the outside.

THE ENGINE, THIS EPISODE

TOM: OUTWARD

The Panama routing traces to a real person. Tom breaks protocol to reach him: the first time the case costs him something personal.

MO: INWARD

The missing file, the partial confession, and a brother she hasn't spoken to in years all converge on the same eight-year-old secret.

ATLANTA TEXTURE (LOCKED LOCATIONS)

- The Midtown law firm (Colony Square area)
- Georgia State Prison, Reidsville (Sandy's introduction)
- The MSMG parking garage (the bug thread continues)

THE LINE

EPISODE 4 (MIDPOINT) • "THE MAN I HAVE"

The season's structural hinge. Tom and Mo both lose their footing in the same hour, for mirrored reasons. Sandy finally tells Mo the truth: years ago he took a plea to protect the family, and he's been quietly cooperating with the FBI ever since. Mo is not the first Sanders the Bureau has used. She just didn't know she had company.

THE STORY

The bank fixer from Episode 3 is dead or gone before the Bureau can get a statement: a clear signal that someone is a step ahead of the investigation. Suspicion turns inward, toward Bailey's own piece. Is there a leak inside the Bureau, or is Dexter simply better informed than the FBI wants to admit? The answer is the latter: Dexter is structurally superior to the Bureau's Atlanta operation. That's the institutional threat.

In the prison visiting room, Sandy tells Mo everything, and Tom, independently, discovers his own cover identity was built years before his assignment, by someone who wanted Mo to trust him before he ever walked through her door.

> *Mo confronts Tom and Bailey together: did the Bureau know about Sandy's arrangement with her family this whole time and never tell her?*

Play this scene as behavior, not as the show asking its own question out loud. This is the relationship's low point: not a lovers' quarrel, an institutional betrayal, which is the correct kind of rupture for this show. And the shadow figure from the Episode 2 garage bug comes into clearer view for the first time: someone we already know.

ESCALATING OBSTACLE

Mo is no longer just fighting Dexter and managing Lyle's silence. She now has to reckon with the possibility that the FBI has been quietly managing her entire family for years, for reasons she still doesn't understand.

KEY MOMENTS

- **A Dead Source.** The cold open: Marcus Levy, the bank fixer, is found dead at the bottom of his dock stairs hours before the Bureau can reach him. Somebody knew they were coming before they did.
- **Who Gave Me My Cover.** Tom finds his own cover identity buried in Sandy's confidential informant file, dated months before his own assignment began.
- **Sandy's Reveal.** The season's longest single scene. Sandy tells Mo the truth about the plea, the FBI, and eleven years of holding a line she never knew existed.
- **The Calendar Trap, Paid Off.** Mo, Becca, and Tom watch the mirrored feed live as someone inside MSMG's own walls takes the bait Becca planted.
- **The Confrontation.** Mo faces Tom and Bailey together. Nobody says the theme out loud. Everybody acts on it.
- **The Second Envelope.** The episode ends alone with Lyle, an envelope marked "Philip. Personal," and a phone call from a voice we've now heard twice.

THE ENGINE, THIS EPISODE

TOM: OUTWARD

His own cover identity turns out to be the mystery. Someone built it years before his assignment: the case just became personal.

MO: INWARD

She learns she isn't the first Sanders the Bureau has used. The family conspiracy and the federal one turn out to be the same conspiracy.

ATLANTA TEXTURE (LOCKED LOCATIONS)

• The prison visiting room, Georgia State Prison, Reidsville (Sandy's reveal)
• The FBI Atlanta field office (Bailey's confrontation)
• A real Atlanta restaurant (the post-confrontation beat)

THE LINE

EPISODE 5 • "OLD ATLANTA" • THE FIRST NAME THAT STICKS

Mo builds a shadow company to move her artists out of Dexter's reach while a stranger's warning and a viral confession collide in the same forty-eight hours. Kane goes nuclear on a rooftop livestream, a photo of Luna's mother's porch arrives with no message attached, and by midnight Tom finally has a name nobody's said out loud in decades: **Harlan Vess.**

THE STORY

Mo unveils Southern Crown Holdings, a shadow entity built to move every MSMG artist's rights somewhere Dexter's ownership stake can never reach, and files Luna's contract first, rushed and imperfect, because a filing that exists beats a perfect one that doesn't. Within four hours, someone she's never met has already read the draft.

On Auburn Avenue, Mo meets Opal Reese, an old fixture of the Royal Peacock scene who knew Philip before MSMG existed. Opal won't give up a name, but she confirms the shape of one: a man who's owned pieces of this city longer than anyone's been willing to say so out loud. Across town, Lyle finally admits to Mo he'll help build Southern Crown, and drives alone to Collier Heights to ask his brother's old associate Augustine Pryce a question he's dreaded since 1987.

Kane doesn't wait for anyone's permission. He livestreams an unscripted confession about predatory contracts from an Atlanta rooftop, and "Protect Your Paper" is trending above the football scores by morning. Hours later, a photograph of Luna's mother's porch arrives with no message attached, and Tom's off-book contact finally confirms the name behind the trust filing that's been redacted since 1987.

> *Harlan Vess. That's who's on the original filing, 1987, before anybody redacted it.*

ESCALATING OBSTACLE

Kane's confession just made MSMG's war a national headline overnight, and a threat against Luna's mother arrived the same night the family's shield finally has a name attached to it. Mo is racing a legal deadline and a viral news cycle at the same time she's just learned the enemy isn't Dexter at all.

KEY MOMENTS

- **The Shadow Company.** Mo unveils Southern Crown Holdings, moving every artist contract out of Dexter's reach before he can burn MSMG to the ground.
- **A Four-Hour-Old Leak.** A Southern Crown draft is read by someone outside the building before the sun comes up. The mole hunt isn't over.
- **The Shape of Him.** Opal Reese, who knew Philip on Auburn Avenue, confirms a nameless man has been quietly owning pieces of this city for fifty years.
- **Protect Your Paper.** Kane's unscripted rooftop confession about predatory contracts goes viral: two hundred thousand views before he leaves the roof.
- **The Porch.** A photograph of Luna's mother's front porch arrives with no message attached, twenty minutes after it was taken.
- **A Name, Finally.** Tom's off-book contact confirms it: Harlan Vess, trustee of record, 1987, redacted in every filing since.

THE ENGINE, THIS EPISODE

TOM: OUTWARD

Benched to "standard reporting" after Bailey reads Sandy's letter, Tom calls in an old favor anyway, and gets back the first name this case has ever had.

MO: INWARD

Building her own shield out of paperwork while a stranger on Auburn Avenue and a warning from Delroy both point toward the same shadow above Dexter.

ATLANTA TEXTURE (LOCKED LOCATIONS)

- Sweet Auburn Historic District: The Royal Peacock (Mo and Opal Reese)
- Underground Atlanta (Luna and Delroy)
- Collier Heights (Lyle and Augustine Pryce)
- Georgia State Prison, Reidsville: Visiting Room (Mo and Sandy)
- An Atlanta rooftop, skyline visible (Kane's livestream)
- The MSMG parking garage (the bug thread continues)

THE LINE

EPISODE 6 • "EVERYBODY OWNS A PIECE" • THE COST OF BEING RIGHT

Kane's livestream becomes a national story overnight, and by the next night somebody firebombs his car with his eight-year-old cousin thirty feet away. Tom trades his badge for a name. And Lyle finally says out loud what he's spent forty-five years not saying: **he's** the reason Harlan Vess's name belongs to this family, not Philip.

THE STORY

Bailey gives Tom forty-eight hours to produce something real, and he spends them anyway, off the books, meeting a source named Marshall at a Waffle House who hands him the notarized proof behind Harlan Vess's name. Neither of them notices the car idling in the lot with a phone raised at windshield height.

That night, someone firebombs Kane's car. Nobody's hurt, but the text that follows, "Tell Tina hi," turns MSMG's whole war personal for the first time. Detective Chandra ties the arson to a break-in and a drowned banker through one repeat license plate, and calls Tom directly, off her own department's books.

At the Sun Dial, Dexter finally tells Mo a truth he's got no reason left to lie about: he didn't steal Philip's catalog, he bought it already stolen. Hours later, a photograph of the Waffle House meeting reaches Reyes's desk and Tom loses his badge. That same night, Lyle hands Mo a black-and-white photograph and confesses the 1981 debt behind Harlan Vess's hold on this family has always been his to carry.

> *Your daddy didn't find them, Mo. I did.*

ESCALATING OBSTACLE

The one man closest to breaking this case just lost the badge that let him work it, and the family's own uncle has just confessed to starting a fire nobody's managed to put out in forty-five years.

KEY MOMENTS

- **Off the Lane, Again.** Tom meets a source at a Waffle House and walks out with a notarized page tying Harlan Vess to the 1987 filing, and a car in the lot he doesn't like the look of.
- **The Fire.** Kane's car goes up with Tina thirty feet away. A text arrives before the flames are even out: "Tell Tina hi."
- **A Pattern, Not a Coincidence.** Chandra ties the arson, a break-in, and a drowned banker to the same repeat license plate.
- **The Sun Dial.** Dexter tells Mo the truth for the first time all season: he bought a catalog he already knew was stolen.
- **The Badge.** A photograph of the Waffle House meeting reaches Reyes's desk before Tom's even back in his car. He's relieved of the case by morning.
- **"I Did."** Lyle finally confesses: he's the one who brought Philip into a room with Harlan Vess in 1981, not the other way around.

THE ENGINE, THIS EPISODE

TOM: OUTWARD

A confidential source, a notarized page, and a car in a parking lot that costs him his badge by sundown: the price of finally moving this case.

MO: INWARD

Two confessions in one night, Dexter's and Lyle's, collapse the line between the family's secrets and the case being built against them.

ATLANTA TEXTURE (LOCKED LOCATIONS)

- FBI Atlanta Field Office: Bullpen and SAC's Office
- Waffle House, Metropolitan Parkway (Tom and Marshall)
- Kane's apartment building, a quiet residential street
- Piedmont Park: Lake Clara Meer (Tom and Chandra)
- The Sun Dial, Westin Peachtree Plaza (Mo and Dexter)
- Dexter Miles Enterprises (Lyle's unseen visit)

THE LINE

EPISODE 7 • "BLOOD AND PAPER" • NOT ONE OF US ALONE

With Tom's OPR hearing looming and Sandy jumped in the prison yard, Lyle finally takes Mo back to where it started, the boarded-up building where Sanders Sound used to be, and hands her the real Schedule B. The name behind the ring turns out to belong to two faces: Harlan Vess, and a woman named **Ruth Ann Colby** who's been running from both of them for thirty-nine years.

THE STORY

Someone queries Sandy's confidential informant file from inside Corrections' own system at four in the morning. Hours later he's jumped in the yard. Bailey doesn't wait for permission before doubling his protection and driving to Reidsville herself.

Rachel and Mo trace Harlan Vess's name through five decades of quiet foreclosures, and a ninety-one-year-old retired law partner named Whitfield gives them the one name nobody's said out loud since 1987: Ruth Ann Colby, the missing witness. Tom and Chandra find her house empty, a storage unit rented under a name that isn't hers, and a car idling in the lot that clears out before either of them can move.

Lyle takes Mo to the ruins of Sanders Sound and finally hands her the real, physical Schedule B, then admits the 1981 debt behind Harlan Vess's hold on this family has always been his to carry, not Philip's. Mo confronts Becca over eight months of leaked patterns traded for a collector's mercy on her mother's loan, and turns the discovery into a plan instead of a firing. By nightfall, four people sit in one room with four pieces of the same truth, and Mo walks out alone toward an unmarked building on Bankhead.

> *Everybody in this room is holding a piece of the same thing. None of us has held all of it.*

ESCALATING OBSTACLE

An OPR hearing could end Tom's career within days, Sandy isn't safe even behind a locked cellblock, and the one witness who could finally prove everything has already run rather than wait to find out if she's next.

KEY MOMENTS

- **Reaching Inside the Walls.** Someone queries Sandy's confidential informant file from inside Corrections at 4 a.m. Hours later, he's jumped in the yard.
- **A Name Nobody Said Since 1987.** A ninety-one-year-old retired law partner gives Rachel and Mo the name of the missing witness: Ruth Ann Colby.
- **The Building Where It Started.** Lyle takes Mo to the ruins of Sanders Sound and finally hands her the real, physical Schedule B.
- **"I Did."** Lyle confesses the 1981 debt behind Harlan Vess's hold on this family has always been his, not Philip's.
- **The Verification Service.** Mo confronts Becca over eight months of leaked patterns, traded for a collector's mercy, and turns her into a willing source instead of firing her.
- **Four Columns, One Table.** Mo, Rachel, Tom, and Chandra put everything on the table at once. Mo walks out alone toward an address Delroy gave her.

THE ENGINE, THIS EPISODE

TOM: OUTWARD

A face for Harlan Vess, forty-five years apart, matched twice, and an unauthorized welfare check that finds a witness's house empty and a storage unit rented under a false calm.

MO: INWARD

The real Schedule B in her hands at last, and the discovery that her uncle isn't the last Sanders keeping a debt secret. Becca's been keeping one too.

ATLANTA TEXTURE (LOCKED LOCATIONS)

- Fulton County Superior Court: Records Room
- The boarded-up Sanders Sound bay, Southwest Atlanta / Old Bankhead
- Reidsville Prison: Warden's Office
- A modest brick ranch home, Covington, Georgia (Ruth Ann Colby's abandoned house)
- Piedmont Park: Lake Clara Meer
- FBI Atlanta Field Office: Ninth Floor Conference Room

THE LINE

EPISODE 8 (SEASON FINALE) • "THE LINE"

> Harlan Vess finally says hello. Mo walks into his archive alone and walks out having decided what kind of owner she's going to be. By the next night, Dexter and Vess are both in custody, four hundred and twelve families are getting their secrets back unsigned in the mail, and Tom is standing on a bridge with a photograph he's finally allowed himself to look at.

THE STORY

Harlan Vess calls Mo inside his own archive and spends a night explaining exactly what he built and why: a floor made out of fifty years of other people's fear, and the one loan in 1981 that started it all. Mo doesn't argue him out of his own logic. She just tells him,

EPISODE 8 (SEASON FINALE) • "THE RECEIPT"

Ruth Ann Colby resurfaces, gives the FBI her full statement, and finally hears that Philip Sanders's daughter knows her name. The warrant moves on Dexter and Vess in the same hour, before either one can hear about the other.

Mo, Rachel, Becca, and Chandra spend one night sorting four hundred and twelve drawers into EVIDENCE and RETURN, and choose, deliberately, to hand back what was never theirs to keep. Lyle steps down. Sandy finally learns the truth about their father. And somewhere in a bullpen days later, a new voice on the phone makes clear Harlan Vess was never the whole operation.

> *It tells you I'm not going to use what's in those drawers the way you used it.*

Harlan Vess finally speaks to Mo directly from inside the archive and explains the philosophy behind his system: paper becomes debt, debt becomes obligation, and obligation becomes leverage. Mo refuses his premise. She will not inherit his method simply because she now possesses his files.

Ruth Ann Colby is found alive and agrees to testify. Federal warrants move on Dexter Miles and Harlan Vess in parallel. Mo confronts Harlan with Tom visible in the doorway, choosing to face him herself without facing him alone. Harlan is taken into custody.

SUPER: THREE MONTHS LATER. After federal and court evidentiary review, material not retained for active prosecution is legally cleared for a victim-restoration process. Mo, Rachel and Becca work only with released material. Mo refuses to exploit the secrets she could use, proving what kind of owner she will be.

KEY MOMENTS

- **"Hello, Monique."** Harlan Vess finally speaks to her directly, from inside his own archive, and spends the whole call explaining exactly what he built and why.
- **Both, Same Hour.** Federal warrants take Dexter Miles and Harlan Vess into custody within minutes of each other, before either can warn the other.
- **Ruth Ann's Statement.** Thirty-nine years of running end in a federal conference room, and Philip Sanders's daughter finally hears the name that could have saved him.
- **One Night, Four Hundred Twelve Drawers.** Mo, Rachel, Becca, and Chandra sort a lifetime of leverage into EVIDENCE and RETURN, and choose to mail people's secrets back unsigned.
- **"Everybody Owns a Piece."** Lyle steps down from MSMG and finally says the season's thesis out loud, alone, to a photograph he's kept face-down since Philip died.
- **Not the Whole Operation.** A new voice calls the FBI bullpen days later: Vess is in custody. The file isn't closed. It's changed hands.

THE ENGINE, THIS EPISODE

TOM: OUTWARD

No badge, one face he's spent eight months learning to read in a crowd, and a front-row seat to watching both of Atlanta's worst-

MO: INWARD

The choice the whole season built toward: not whether to beat Harlan Vess, but what kind of owner to become once she finally

KEY MOMENTS

• "Hello, Monique." Harlan finally speaks to Mo directly from inside the archive.
• Ruth Ann's Statement. Thirty-nine years of running ends when she agrees to testify.
• Same Hour. Federal warrants move on Dexter Miles and Harlan Vess in parallel.
• Doorway. Mo faces Harlan herself, with Tom visible behind her as the witness she chose to bring.
• Three Months Later. Only court-cleared, non-evidentiary personal files enter the restoration process.
• The Unopened File. Mo refuses leverage she could use, rejecting Harlan's philosophy instead of inheriting it.
• Ownership Requires Consent. Mo writes the season's final answer on the Southern Crown whiteboard.

- Hartsfield-Jackson Airport: Arrivals
- A small venue, West End (Luna's unrecorded set)
- Jackson Street Bridge (the season's closing image)

NCCA ENTERTAINMENT

THE LINE

Everybody owns a piece. Nobody owns the truth.